

Chapter 39-1: Divine Sword

Ning Fuyi's sudden action caught Chu Qingqiu off guard. She only felt herself lifted off the ground, and when she came to her senses again, she had already fallen into the young woman's embrace. Her face immediately flushed with warmth, and she opened her mouth to scold, but was interrupted by Ning Fuyi's hushing sound.

"There are demon clan members nearby. Let's leave this place first, then make plans," Ning Fuyi said while concealing their aura and running toward the other end of the stone chamber.

Using her toe to touch a protruding stone brick, the stone door in front of them opened silently.

Ning Fuyi quickly ran out of the stone chamber. Outside was a wide corridor. From the dust-covered murals, one could see that this place had once been resplendent with gold and jade, but now, after tens of thousands of years, all that splendor had been buried by time.

Chu Qingqiu nestled in the young woman's embrace, her body swaying with Ning Fuyi's movements. Having no choice, she reached out to steady herself on Ning Fuyi's shoulder, then forcefully closed her eyes, unwilling to imagine how she looked being carried by Ning Fuyi.

But she had to admit that despite Ning Fuyi's young age, her arms were soft yet steady.

So she said nothing more and didn't struggle.

Ning Fuyi followed the vague route from her memories to hide, walking through the winding corridors. With her right foot, she stepped on a switch, turned, and entered a hidden chamber.

In her previous life, she had hidden here from the Zhaoyao Saintess¹.

As soon as the hidden door closed, she placed Chu Qingqiu on the ground. Although cultivators' physiques were better than ordinary people, she was still a young woman's body after all, and it was difficult to carry an adult woman for too long.

Chu Qingqiu bit her lip to endure the pain. As soon as she was set down, she turned her head away, as if unwilling to look at Ning Fuyi's face.

Ning Fuyi paid her no mind and instead looked down to examine her wound, beginning to search through her storage bead. Finally, she pulled out a glass bottle—the holy water she had obtained during the competition that day.

Then she was about to untie Chu Qingqiu's clothes, but the back of her hand stung sharply as it was slapped away.

"Divine Venerable," Ning Fuyi said somewhat helplessly, "I'm just treating your wound, I don't have any ill intentions."

"This venerable doesn't need others to treat her wounds," Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice. She reached out to take the glass bottle, but as soon as she extended her hand, blood and demonic energy began gurgling out together.

She immediately gasped and leaned back against the wall, her slender neck beading with droplets of sweat.

"What are you trying to prove?" Ning Fuyi crouched in place. With no outsiders present, she was too lazy to pretend respect and snatched back the glass bottle.

This time Chu Qingqiu said nothing more, only kept her head turned to one side, showing only half her profile.

Ning Fuyi used one hand to unfasten Chu Qingqiu's garments. The body that was usually covered tightly finally revealed its curves. Ning Fuyi's hand paused, and suddenly the scene she had witnessed in that illusion that day appeared in her mind.

She quickly closed her eyes, forcefully driving that image away.

After her mind was completely empty, she opened her eyes again, but didn't continue. Instead, she manifested a sharp small knife and slowly cut away the clothing around the wound, exposing the blood-soaked skin underneath.

She didn't know what had caused the injury, but it was extremely severe. A little higher and it would have injured a vital point. Ning Fuyi felt a retroactive fear as she poured the holy water onto the torn skin.

Chu Qingqiu suddenly let out a painful muffled groan, the sound almost like a whimper. She suddenly reached out, wanting to grasp something.

Ning Fuyi's mind heated up, and she extended her own hand. Her wrist was immediately gripped tightly.

The slippery sweat carried the woman's warmth, the sensation vivid. Ning Fuyi's hand almost trembled, but in the end she controlled the direction well and didn't spill the holy water.

This wasn't the first time she had seen Chu Qingqiu injured, but this time her feelings were completely different from before.

Her gaze fell on Chu Qingqiu's sweaty neck, then moved upward. Those beautiful white teeth were biting her lip, her peach blossom eyes tightly closed, forcibly enduring.

Ning Fuyi's eyes darkened as she lowered her head to focus on treating the wound.

The wound was truly serious, but fortunately the holy water was truly effective. Soon the demonic energy was dispelled, and the skin healed visibly, finally becoming smooth as jade.

Ning Fuyi then felt around in her storage bead and asked, "Do you want clothes?"

Chu Qingqiu seemed to have exhausted all her strength by now. She weakly shook her head, lightly hooked her finger, and the torn clothes on her body were restored to new.

The bloody smell in the narrow space finally faded. Ning Fuyi exhaled and, with her knees going soft, sat down in place as well, waiting for Chu Qingqiu to recover.

Although Chu Qingqiu's strength had always been a mystery to others, it was clear that she had just exerted herself to barely withstand the Chaos Realm², and now with blood loss, her physical condition should be at the end of her tether.

If those demon clan members came, they would have almost no chance of winning.

Ning Fuyi couldn't help feeling irritated. In her previous life, she had dominated the entire demon realm, and no demon clan member dared provoke her. But now, trapped in this weak body, she was no match for anyone.

She had to obtain the Emei Thorn³ and restore her power as soon as possible.

Thinking this, Ning Fuyi suddenly raised her hand to cast a barrier over Chu Qingqiu and got up to leave the hidden chamber. However, Chu Qingqiu's hand had been gripping her wrist the whole time and now tightened forcefully, pulling her back.

"Where are you going?" Chu Qingqiu asked through her pain.

"To find an exit. The demon clan is nearby. We can't stay trapped here waiting to die," Ning Fuyi said in a low voice.

She couldn't tell Chu Qingqiu that she was looking for the Emei Thorn, so she could only make an excuse.

"It's useless. The exit has been sealed by them. We can't get out for now," Chu Qingqiu shook her head.

"Moreover, that person's demonic energy is something even I can barely resist. If you encounter them, you won't even have a chance to cry for help!" Chu Qingqiu added.

"But..."

"Shh." Chu Qingqiu suddenly interrupted her words. She supported herself with the white bone in her hand and stood up. Though her body was still swaying, she was much better than before.

"They're coming," Chu Qingqiu said in almost a whisper.

Though she was forcing herself to stand, her back showed no sign of hunching. She still stood tall and upright, her bloodless face unable to conceal the sharp intent emanating from her.

At the same time, Ning Fuyi also sensed the approach of demonic energy. Her spirit tensed as she slowly retreated to the corner.

"This hidden door can't stop them," Ning Fuyi said, and her toe somehow touched another mechanism. Behind her, another door appeared, slowly opening to reveal another location on the other side.

Chu Qingqiu watched her actions, a flash of surprise passing through her eyes, though this surprise quickly faded, as if she was used to it.

At this critical moment, Ning Fuyi wasn't afraid of exposing the fact that she had been to the Divine Meteorite⁴ before. She grabbed Chu Qingqiu and led her away from the hidden chamber, rushing into the gold and silver splendor behind them.

This room seemed to be specifically for storing treasures. The ground was covered with various beautiful jade and gold and silver items. Precious treasures and unknown magical artifacts were scattered carelessly like garbage, piled into small mountains.

The Zhaoyao Saintess had guarded the Divine Meteorite for generations, precisely to protect the treasures that had been buried here for countless tens of thousands of years, preventing the world from fighting bloodily over them.

But Ning Fuyi wasn't interested in any of these. She just walked quickly through the rare treasures, soon making her way out. This time, what met her eyes was a pile of bones. The bones had already crumbled on the ground, but from the size of those bones, one could see what a terrifying massive creature had once guarded this place.

When she had used an array to search for the Emei Thorn that day, she had roughly deduced the direction where the Emei Thorn was located. Combined with her memories of having been to the Divine Meteorite before, she could roughly determine which way to go.

However, the demonic energy behind them was getting closer and closer, seeming to surround them from all directions, making it difficult to escape. At this time, a slight sound of something cutting through air came. Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu stopped at the same time, both retreating to avoid an extremely thin and long silver thread.

The silver thread brushed past their noses and landed on the ruined wall behind them, then quickly retracted. There was a thunderous roar, and the entire wall was torn to shreds like paper, with dust flying everywhere.

Chu Qingqiu pulled Ning Fuyi away from the wall. After the dust settled, a monster appeared before them, making even Chu Qingqiu feel nauseous.

"What the hell is that thing?" Ning Fuyi closed her eyes in disgust, too nauseated to look more.

The creature had eight distinctly jointed, hairy long legs that lifted its body nearly to the unreachable high ceiling. The thin thread from before had been shot from its tail. Now those eight legs were moving together in reverse, and its massive body turned in a circle, revealing its front.

On a spider's body, there was actually a weasel's face. But this weasel wasn't furry like ordinary ones—its face was composed of pitch-black skin, its eyes bulging round, its mouth curled up in a bizarre arc. Looking at it longer, it seemed like a human face, making one's hair stand on end.

"It's a demon beast," Chu Qingqiu said, holding the white bone horizontally in front of her, her voice weak. "It must have been trapped in the Divine Meteorite for tens of thousands of years to have transformed into this appearance."

Ning Fuyi endured the irritation this thing caused to her eyes and tried to pull Chu Qingqiu away. However, as soon as she took a step, several silver threads shot out, instantly forming a large net in front of them, controlling their escape route.

The demon beast seemed to have been hungry for a long time and was impatiently trying to devour them. It had already opened its bloody maw, approaching them with its foul breath.

At the same time, an extremely oppressive roar came from Chu Qingqiu's sleeve, and then the white tiger's form manifested in the room, expanding to several times its size. Though it couldn't reach the ceiling, it shattered the left and right walls again. Bai Lin⁵ let out a long howl, then immediately pounced toward the demon beast.

The two massive bodies immediately wrestled together, their collision causing the ground to shake. Flying sand and stones scattered everywhere, making it impossible to keep one's eyes open, with only a few afterimages visible.

"There's miasma!" Chu Qingqiu suddenly said. Her voice seemed very weak amidst the chaos of battle. As soon as she finished speaking, Ning Fuyi also smelled a pungent odor.

All skin that came into contact with the gas began to itch, clearly showing that simply holding one's breath wouldn't work. Ning Fuyi's back was already against the wall. She frantically felt around with her eyes closed and finally found the mechanism.

Just as she pressed down hard, there was suddenly empty space behind her. She fell backward into the hidden chamber, at the same time tightly grasping Chu Qingqiu's hand. The two fell into it together, and the hidden chamber door slammed shut.

Immediately everything became pitch black, with the outside noise cut off, leaving only a faint sound audible.

However, another sound became increasingly obvious, until it seemed deafening. It took Ning Fuyi a moment to realize it was her heartbeat.

It wasn't because of anything else, but because this stone chamber was too narrow, causing the two to be almost face-to-face pressed together, close enough to completely feel each other's warmth.

And to smell the clear, cold fragrance on Chu Qingqiu's body.

Ning Fuyi felt her body go rigid. She tried hard to stand on her tiptoes against the stone wall, so her nose wouldn't touch Chu Qingqiu's chin.

And Chu Qingqiu was currently supporting herself with one hand against the wall behind Ning Fuyi, giving the feeling of having her enclosed in her embrace.

Stop beating, Ning Fuyi commanded her heart, but it completely ignored her and continued beating loudly.

She wondered if Chu Qingqiu could hear it. Ning Fuyi closed her eyes, waiting for the battle outside to subside.

But her worry was obviously unnecessary, because Chu Qingqiu seemed unable to stand steady anymore. Her body was slowly sliding down against Ning Fuyi. Ning Fuyi quickly reached out with both hands and embraced her waist, giving her some support.

That waist was even thinner than she had imagined, so thin it seemed like it might break at any moment. This made Ning Fuyi start to worry whether Chu Qingqiu might die here.

"Chu Qingqiu..."

"Shut up," Chu Qingqiu said in a whisper, her voice weak but still stern.

Ning Fuyi said nothing more. She shifted her attention away from the person in front of her and carefully listened to the sounds outside.

Footnotes:

¹ **Zhaoyao Saintess (招摇圣女)** - A sacred guardian figure associated with Zhaoyao Mountain, responsible for protecting ancient treasures and maintaining order.

² **Chaos Realm (混沌境)** - A mystical dimensional space often used for trials and training, separate from the normal world.

³ **Emei Thorn (峨眉刺)** - A legendary weapon that Ning Fuyi is seeking to reclaim from her previous life.

⁴ **Divine Meteorite (神陨)** - An ancient sacred site where divine beings once fell, now containing powerful treasures and dangers.

⁵ **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Chu Qingqiu's spirit beast companion, a white tiger with powerful abilities.